WOLFE

BY DORIAN WOLFE

FREE CHECKLIST

SCAM RED-FLAG CHECKLIST

Ten warning signs of a dating scam, what to do if something feels wrong, and where to report it.

CHECKLIST

10 RED FLAGS

Tick any that apply to someone you met online. One flag is a reason to slow down. **Two or more: stop and talk to someone you trust.**

- [ ] Their photos look too perfect, or a reverse image search finds the same pictures under another name.
- [ ] They want to move from the app to WhatsApp, Telegram or text within days.
- [ ] They say "I love you" or call you "soulmate" very quickly, before you have met.
- [ ] They always have a reason not to video call or meet in person.
- [ ] They live or work far away: overseas, military, a ship, an oil rig, "a doctor abroad".
- [ ] Their story has gaps or changes when you ask simple questions.
- [ ] A sudden emergency: hospital bill, customs fee, plane ticket, "business problem".
- [ ] They ask for money, gift cards, crypto, wire transfers or your bank details, in any amount.
- [ ] They pressure you to act fast, or to keep the relationship secret from family and friends.
- [ ] They bring up an investment or trading app ("my cousin made a fortune").

REMEMBER

Real people will happily video call, meet in a public place, and let you take your time. Scammers cannot.

IF SOMETHING FEELS WRONG

WHAT TO DO

1. Stop	Do not send more money or personal information. Do not confront them: it can make things worse.
2. Keep evidence	Screenshots, usernames, phone numbers, payment details, dates.
3. Call your bank	Call your bank or card provider straight away. Speed matters.
4. Report	US: reportfraud.ftc.gov (FTC) and ic3.gov (FBI). UK: Action Fraud / Report Fraud. Elsewhere: your local police or consumer authority. Also report the profile on the dating app.
5. Tell someone	A friend, family member or helpline. Scammers rely on shame and secrecy.
6. Be kind to yourself	It is not your fault. Skilled criminals do this for a living.

SAFE-MEETING RULES

- Video call before you meet.
- Meet in a public place and tell a friend where you are going.
- Use your own transport.
- Keep your address, workplace and finances private until you really know the person.

THE NUMBERS

The FTC reported that people aged 60 and over lost about $2.4 billion to fraud in 2024 (all fraud types, not only romance). Check the FTC site for current figures.